peace initiatives, President Thein Sein formed union-level peace teams in May 2012, namely the Union Peacemaking Central Committee (UPCC) and the Union Peacemaking Working Committee (UPWC) (Myanmar Peace Monitor 2015). The UPCC was formally the highest authority in the peace process, having among its members constitutionally powerful decision-makers, such as the president, the army chief, heads from both houses of parliament, and numbers of ministers responsible for security-related ministries (Tin Maung Maung Than 2014). The UPWC held the highest mandate for peace policy implementation, being accountable to the central committee. Vice President Dr Sai Mauk Kham chaired the UPWC, while Aung Min from Team A, Thein Zaw from Team B, and the army commander were deputy chairmen. It consisted of fifty-two members in total, including union ministers, regional and state chief ministers, regional commanders, and ethnic lawmakers.

Challenges and continuity

The peace process has not been smooth sailing. At times, disagreements between the Tatmadaw and the EAGs brought the process to a standstill (Tin Maung Maung Than 2014, p. 113). Conflicts arose on several fronts. The contents of the peace discussions sporadically sparked tensions between the military and ethnic counterparts. Establishment of a federal army and topics under the DDR policy have been especially sensitive. Likewise, armed clashes on the ground occasionally have halted peace talks. For instance, fighting erupted between the Tatmadaw and ethnic armies, such as the KIA, Ta'ang National Liberation Army (TNLA), and the Myanmar National Democratic Alliance Army (MNDAA) in late 2014 and the first quarter of 2015, delaying the peace talks.

Under the military government, there was no official "negotiating institution" for making ceasefire deals with the EAGs. With the current peace process, the government peace team attempted to act as a third party negotiator and often managed to secure promising deals with the Tatmadaw and the EAGs. Instances include the agreements on a federal system of government in August 2014, deeds of commitment in February 2015, the Nationwide Ceasefire Agreement (NCA) draft of April 2015, signing of the NCA with eight EAGs in October 2015, and the framework for political dialogue developed in December 2015.